

Viviendo con Plutón (I)

Liz Greene es una de las astrólogas más influyentes del período de posguerra. Sobre el trabajo de quienes la antecedieron, como Alan Leo y Dane Rudhyar, e inspirada en la psicología del siglo XX, particularmente en los escritos de C.G. Jung, creó la astrología psicológica, enraizada en la comprensión de la psicología como un proceso dinámico más que como la descripción de la personalidad. Empezando con Saturn en 1976 (edición en español Saturno. Un nuevo enfoque de un viejo diablo. Ediciones Obelisco, Barcelona, 1986) y Relating en 1977(edición en español, Relaciones Humanas, Un enfoque psicológico de la Astrología, Ediciones Urano, Barcelona, 1987), ha producido una serie de libros excelentes donde profundiza y elabora su original visión de la astrología como la posibilidad de conocer nuestros potenciales, más que saber quienes somos. Liz Greene tiene un Doctorado en Psicología, así como el Diploma de la Facultad de Estudios Astrológicos(de la que ella es patrocinadora) y es una calificada analista jungiana. Es directora del Centro de Astrología Psicológica que fundó en 1983 junto con el fallecido Howard Sasportas. Para los cursos y seminarios del Centro, ver: <http://www.astro.com/cgi/redirect.cgi/www.cpalondon.com> Conocí a Liz Greene en Londres en ocasión de hacer esta entrevista, el 14 de Agosto de 2001. En vista del desastre del 11 de septiembre, sus manifestaciones acerca del Saturno-Plutón Zeitgeist(vocablo alemán que describe el concepto de la cualidad o el espíritu de un período de la historia), toman ahora un tinte profundamente profético. El artículo original apareció en la revista astrológica americana "The Mountain Astrologer"(Dic/Ene 2002), cuya edición todavía está disponible en su página web: <http://www.astro.com/cgi/redirect.cgi/www.mountainastrologer.com/>

Nick Campion: Para comenzar, Liz, quisiera hablar un poco sobre Plutón, el planeta del momento, especialmente en vista de la actual oposición Saturno-Plutón. He estado leyendo lo que escribiste sobre Saturno-Plutón en tu libro Saturno; afirmas que cuando estos planetas se

combinan, "a menudo hay un cuidadoso y deliberadamente organizado movimiento hacia alguna clase de experiencia autodestructiva"[1] Añades que la persona quizá es conciente de esta actividad obsesiva, pero puede no ser capaz de controlarlo. En este momento, yo tengo esta oposición Saturno-Plutón en cuadratura a mi Sol, por lo tanto, estaba pensando "¿Cómo puedo volverme conciente de ello?, de hecho, ¿Cómo se vuelve uno conciente de algo?" ¿Qué experiencias tienes tú con esta posición en lo que se refiere a tus clientes? ¿Ha sido palpable?

Liz Greene: Oh sí muy palpable. No hay mucha gente que no la esté sintiendo de una forma u otra, porque no sólo involucra a los planetas en los signos mutables. También, está actuando por semicuadratura y sesquicuadratura y por lo tanto, involucra igualmente a todos los signos cardinales. Por lo tanto, sí, muchos clientes están empezando a mostrar el síndrome del caparazón de armadillo.

Nick Champion: ¿Quieres decir que están tomando una actitud autodefensiva?

Liz Greene: Esa es una de las posibles reacciones. Creo que es una reacción muy común y probablemente una reacción natural. Saturno se nota de una forma mucho más individual, en tanto que Plutón se siente tan abrumadoramente, que la respuesta inicial es ir hacia Saturno y tratar de defenderse de Plutón. No es que esto sea una equivocación. Es inevitable, es la forma natural de reaccionar. Pero no es necesariamente lo mejor que pueda hacerse. El aspecto actuará de todas formas por sí mismo, pero, en realidad, esto es lo que la gente parece estar haciendo.

Nick Champion: En vista de las respectivas posiciones planetarias, ¿crees que esta oposición Saturno-Plutón tiene una definitiva particularidad Géminis-Sagitario?

Liz Greene: Creo que sí, porque parece que surgen cuestiones relacionadas con la moralidad, así como con el conocimiento versus alguna clase de comprensión intuitiva. Está creando una gran polarización intelectual. Hay ideas que están siendo confrontadas, aunque la forma que toma la oposición Saturno-Plutón puede ser muy concreta en la vida de mucha gente. Con todos los conflictos que parecen presentarse, tanto en el nivel personal como en el colectivo, es la ideología, los sistemas de creencias y los cuerpos del conocimiento, los que se cuestionan, detrás de cualquier guerra que se esté librando.

Nick Champion: ¿Hay en este momento algún ejemplo particular de controversia ideológica al que apuntarías?

Liz Greene: Bien, ¿Qué te parece Irlanda del Norte? Tiene lugar ya hace

muchísimo tiempo, aunque no creo que este sea el único relacionado con Saturno-Plutón, pero quizá entre ahora en una nueva fase.

Nick Campion: El sol en la carta de Reino Unido de Gran Bretaña e Irlanda del Norte(7 de diciembre de 1922) está a 14 grados de Sagitario.[2]

Liz Greene: El sol y el descendente están a cinco grados uno del otro. Existe un día de diferencia entre la carta de la República de Irlanda[3] y la carta del Reino Unido, incluida Irlanda del Norte. Ambas están bajo la influencia de Saturno-Plutón.

Nick Campion: A menudo, existe una completa incapacidad de una parte para ver el punto de vista de la otra. Y hasta para reconocer que existe otro punto de vista. ¿A qué arquetipo crees que corresponde Plutón? ¿No es un poco artificial decir "Este planeta corresponde a este arquetipo y este otro a aquel otro arquetipo?", como si existieran en compartimentos estancos?

Liz Greene: Si, es artificial.

Nick Campion: Hablaste sobre Plutón en un momento dado, como Lucifer, el ángel de la oscuridad que trae la noche, y hablaste sobre Plutón en algún otro sitio, como femenino y luego también como el arquetipo de la inmortalidad y del interminable ciclo de la muerte y el renacimiento.[4]

Liz Greene: No creo que pueda tomarse un planeta, luego un arquetipo y decir que encajan a la perfección, porque eso sería intentar mezclar dos sistemas simbólicos que nunca encajarán adecuadamente. Probablemente, es mejor ver a los símbolos planetarios como si tuvieran relaciones familiares con una amplia gama de imágenes que combina todas ellas de diferentes maneras. Uno de los arquetipos plutonianos es ciertamente Lucifer. Otro, la Fatalidad. Otro, es Mephistopheles de Goethe y otro, es Kali. Hay todo un espectro de imágenes míticas que pueden ayudarnos a comprender el principio de Plutón. Es casi imposible articularlo, excepto en poéticas metáforas. Hay una vida inteligente en la sustancia misma que parece estar asociada con la fuerza vital en los seres vivos. Es la propia naturaleza o fuerza vital de la naturaleza que sobrevivirá. Y para sobrevivir, por fuerza, debe sufrir permutaciones, cambios, procesos de muerte que destruyen formas que han superado su vigencia, para luego generar nuevas. Experimentamos a Plutón como algo destructivo, entonces, lo asociamos a Mefistófeles. Si lo experimentamos como nutritivo y entonces aparece la Gran Madre. Si lo experimentamos como la Fatalidad, entonces, percibimos la imagen de

Moirá, el Destino Griego. Necesitamos numerosas imágenes porque lo percibimos de diferentes maneras.

Nick Campion: Plutón fue descubierto en 1930 y los astrólogos, a menudo, hablan sobre la conexión entre el fascismo y la irrupción en la conciencia del arquetipo plutoniano. Es tan fuerte la correlación, que es difícil de ignorar. Pero, ¿crees que desde ese momento el arquetipo de Plutón ha sido más fuerte?

Liz Greene: No creo que se haya fortalecido. Lo que pasa es que tenemos más conciencia de él que antes, como algo que está operando tanto en la sociedad como en la naturaleza, aunque no creo que sea más fuerte. Y aunque sea difícil ignorar el ascenso del fascismo y el descubrimiento de la energía nuclear, creo que debemos ser prudentes, porque los dictadores, los genocidas, las invasiones masivas, los cataclismos y las muertes, siempre existieron. La diferencia es que ahora hay conciencia de este arquetipo de Plutón al que le damos un nombre. Somos más conscientes de que opera en el mundo, y esta conciencia quizá, da más lugar a que se use o abuse de él de manera consciente. Esto no lo hace necesariamente más fuerte. Sólo significa que empezamos a incluirlo en lugar de actuar de manera ciega e inconsciente.

Nick Campion: En términos de representar, estuve leyendo *The Horoscope in Manifestation* (La Manifestación del Horóscopo). [5] En un punto dices a alguien en el seminario: "Tú actúas en la obra" y entonces la persona responde: "¿Yo actúo?" y tú dices: "Sí, actúas a Júpiter". De esta manera ¿Cómo esperas que una persona actúe a Plutón?. ¿Cómo enfocarías a alguien que viene con un fuerte problema plutoniano?

Liz Greene: Empezaría por escucharle y hablar sobre ello, de lo que está sintiendo y experimentando con este problema. Los planetas exteriores pueden sentirse tan abrumadoramente, que, para esa persona, es fácil perder completamente sus límites. Es esto lo que la persona suele padecer durante el curso de los tránsitos de Plutón. Cualquier cosa que le permita a la persona tomar perspectiva, le ayudará inmediatamente. Ya sea que el sentimiento de ser dominado sea interno o externo, es muy importante que la persona sea capaz de decir, "Estoy desesperado, siento que a mí alrededor todo se estuviese muriendo" Es importante tratar de encontrar el terreno de la percepción individual y salir de la sensación abrumadora general. Así que siempre empezaría por preguntar como se siente la persona, antes de empezar a hablar sobre lo que el planeta significa. Lo que ocurre, a veces, es que la gente se

desconecta de sus sentimientos porque se atemorizan. He notado que para algunas personas que están bajo la influencia de un tránsito de Plutón, el sentimiento de estar sobrecogido es tan terrible, especialmente si el ego es frágil, que se desconectan. Y luego, empiezan a comportarse como Plutón. Son poseídos por cualquier cosa que esté bullendo.

Nick Champion: ¿Actuar Plutón sería comportarse de manera obsesiva?

Liz Greene: Sí.

Nick Champion: Confronta?

Liz Greene: No confronta necesariamente. Plutón puede ser muy circunspecto aunque insista en su actitud de "Esto es de vida o muerte y tengo que ganar o seré destruido". Por eso, la gente se comporta, a veces, tan mal. Se involucra en luchas de poder y empieza a manipular o se establece en una situación de víctima de algo muy poderoso. Plutón no es necesariamente confrontativo. Está dentro de un patrón de la naturaleza y es una fuerza que arrasa todo o se convierte en víctima de algo.

Nick Champion: Ponerse uno mismo en la posición de la víctima con relación a la autoridad, parece ser la clásica combinación Sol-Plutón.

Liz Greene: Sí, realmente es una de las manifestaciones clásicas. ¿Te refieres al aspecto en la carta natal o por tránsito?

Nick Champion: Natal. ¿Pero haces diferencia entre los aspectos natales y por tránsito?

Liz Greene: Si, porque si es natal es un proceso continuo. Si es un tránsito sin un aspecto natal, es una experiencia que la persona atraviesa pero quizá, no sea una sobre la cual tenga que construir su vida. Si es natal, es necesario conocer qué dimensión de la vida debe incluir y concientizar. Tiene que establecer alguna clase de relación con ella para vivirla.

Nick Champion: Si alguien tiene una combinación Sol-Plutón natal, puede tenerla bien integrada a su forma de ser, así que cuando tiene lugar un tránsito de Plutón, podría sentirlo menos profundamente que alguien que tiene el mismo tránsito pero sin la posición natal.

Liz Greene: Quizá, no "mucho menos profundo", pero sí más familiar. El individuo podría decir, "Sí, ya sé esto, pero ahora la potencia es mayor". Mientras que si no hay un aspecto natal diría, "¿Qué es esto?". Ayuda mucho tener un aspecto de Plutón con el ascendente, el Sol, la Luna, Mercurio, o tenerlo en una casa angular, porque cuando tiene lugar un tránsito de Plutón, ya existe la percepción de la dimensión plutoniana de la vida. Esto requiere que el ser humano acepte que en la vida opera algo

mayor a sí mismo. No se puede manejar la energía plutoniana sin admitir esto. Frente a ella, es más fácil navegar si se la conoce. De otra manera, puede ser un tiempo muy complicado.

Nick Campion: Entonces, obviamente algo útil que la gente puede ganar con la consulta astrológica, es conocer la descripción de la energía que tiene que enfrentar. El astrólogo le pondrá una etiqueta identificatoria y entonces, la objetivizarán y de alguna manera, le asociarán a una presencia o a una personalidad con la cual relacionarse.

Liz Greene: Sí, es la misma técnica con la que operan la imaginación activa o el trabajo de ensoñación. Si se le brinda un contenedor a cualquier experiencia que se atraviesa, a través de un símbolo, como un símbolo astrológico o una pintura, un dibujo o una pieza de música, se puede poner distancia entre uno y la experiencia. Quizá, no se pueda objetivarla y saber qué es, pero se obtiene la sensación de relacionarse con la energía, en lugar de sentirse tragado por ella y la conciencia puede asumirla.

Nick Campion: ¿Que distinción harías entre un vínculo Luna-Plutón y otro Sol-Plutón? ¿Luna-Plutón está más relacionado con la familia?

Liz Greene: Creo que sí. Luna-Plutón opera mucho más a través de la herencia física y psicológica. Uno experimenta la dimensión plutoniana de la vida visceralmente, en el cuerpo o a través de los sentimientos o a través de las relaciones. Opera en el nivel de "las tripas", mientras que Sol-Plutón se traduce más en algo que afecta o que es parte del destino de uno, de su propósito y de su dirección en la vida.

Nick Campion: En "The Horoscope in Manifestation" (La manifestación del Horóscopo), tu le dices a un miembro de la audiencia con Plutón en cuadratura a su Luna: "Acarreas complejos relacionados con tu herencia familiar, el mundo herido, el sufrimiento de los otros y los compromisos que tal sufrimiento invoca"[6] Esto parece estar más relacionado con el pasado, en oposición a Sol-Plutón que está más relacionado con el futuro.

Liz Greene: Sí, Luna-Plutón trae consigo un gran baúl lleno de objetos familiares, sacados del ático y el sótano familiar.

Nick Campion: ¿Secretos familiares?

Liz Greene: Sí, el niño que nace con Luna-Plutón sabe que la vida es muy peligrosa. Nada es permanente, todo podría ser destruido. No existe la posibilidad de relajarse y estar a salvo por un tiempo, porque hay una comprensión innata o un conocimiento instintivo de los ciclos naturales de la vida y de la finitud de todas las cosas, de la inevitabilidad de los

cambios. Esa sensación de peligro constante puede convertirse en un atributo extraordinario. También, conlleva una comprensible tendencia a la depresión, porque simplemente no se puede disfrutar de las cosas efímeras, como una fiesta. En realidad, se puede, pero en algún punto cuando dan las doce, uno se da cuenta que toda esa gente un día será vieja, enfermará y morirá. ¿Qué sentido tiene esa fiesta? ¿Para qué están allí? Esto alimenta toda clase de cuestiones profundas y ansiedades.

Nick Campion: Un punto que desarrollas intensamente en tus primeros escritos es la idea de que esta combinación planetaria, que podría tener una posible consecuencia negativa, también provee el medio para hacer algo al respecto. Por lo tanto, si Luna-Plutón provoca una tendencia natural a la depresión, ¿cuál sería la forma natural en que alguien pueda convertir esto en un camino ascendente, o para llevarlo a la luz, o como quieras expresarlo para que le vuelva la sonrisa a la cara?

Liz Greene: Creo que quizá supone no intentar tan denodadamente volver a sonreír. Parte del problema es que percibimos estados de depresión y duelo, como estados patológicos que deberían ser curados. Media América está medicada para evitar la depresión. La depresión o la melancolía, tiene una larga tradición de ser el único estado en el cual puedes contactar con el alma. Si vas por el mundo con una sonrisa perpetua, este plano de la vida, no puede darse a conocer de una forma útil y creativa. La cíclica tendencia a la depresión con Luna-Plutón, significa, en primera instancia, entender la depresión de forma diferente, quizá llamándola melancolía y hundirse en sus profundidades para poder volver a la luz. Surgen todas las cuestiones más profundas. Como en el mundo de Plutón todo muere, se sufre constantemente por lo que desaparece. Es como perder a un ser querido y a menos que se atravesase el proceso de duelo, algo se obstruirá y enfermará. Realmente, puede ser útil trabajar con la depresión como algo válido y creativo, en lugar de tratar de volver a sonreír. Creo que la sonrisa comienza a tomar la forma de ironía. Es una diferente clase de sonrisa. La sonrisa puede volverse irónica y llevarle a desarrollar el tipo de humor que pasa por el absurdo.

Nick Campion: Recuerdo que una vez, hace mucho tiempo, había un artículo en el boletín de la Asociación Astrológica. Eve Jackson, observaba un tránsito en las cartas natales del grupo Monty Python y la prevalencia de Plutón.[7] Uno piensa en la imagen del payaso triste con las lágrimas rodando por su cara.

Liz Greene: Plutón tiene su propia manera de sonreír. Es un error pensar que la sonrisa debería ser siempre la sonrisa de Steinway, que siempre parece decir: "Que tengas un buen día". Regenerar y honrar a Plutón, realmente quiere decir tratar al dios con respeto y no intentar convertirlo en una colección de sonrisas.

Nick Campion: Una imagen que se me ha ocurrido mientras tu hablabas, es una de esas vistas que encuentras en los países mediterráneos, de oscuras iglesias católicas con viejas de negro, encendiendo velas, probablemente, por los miembros perdidos de la familia. Esta es su forma de trabajar con Plutón y la pérdida.

Liz Greene: Sí, puede ser apropiado para estas culturas. Pero no tienen porqué funcionar en Inglaterra. Además, algunas culturas temen mucho menos abrirse al dolor y a la rabia que viene con él, porque realmente es normal enfurecerse cuando algo muere. De nuevo, si observas a Fausto, Goethe tenía el Sol en cuadratura a Plutón en el ascendente en Escorpio. En un momento, Mefistófeles dice, "¿Cuál es el problema si esta mujer muere?" Y Fausto salta enfurecido y dice que la muerte de una sola joven mujer como esa, es una terrible tragedia. Deberíamos experimentar esta reacción frente a Plutón. Es apropiado, porque de esa manera limpiamos la rabia y el dolor. En algunas culturas hacen esto con más facilidad.

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Nick Campion fue Presidente de la Asociación Astrológica de Gran Bretaña. Estudia astrología desde principios de los 70 y ha enseñando esta asignatura desde 1980 en el Instituto Camden de Londres, la Facultad de Estudios Astrológicos y más recientemente, en la Universidad Kepler. Actualmente, cursa un posgrado en el Departamento de Estudios de las Religiones en la Universidad de Bath Spa, Inglaterra. Nick obtuvo el premio Marc Edmund Jones en 1992, el Premio George Antares en 1994 y el premio Spica 1999 a la Excelencia Profesional. Entre sus libros figuran: Mundane Astrology (Astrología Mundana) y The Book of World Horoscopes (El Libro de los Horóscopos del Mundo). Existe información disponible sobre sus libros en su página web:

<http://www.astro.com/cgi/redirect.cgi/www.nickcampion.com/>

[1] Liz Greene, Saturno. Un nuevo enfoque de un viejo diablo. Ediciones Obelisco,

Barcelona, 1986.

[2] Nicholas Campion, Book of World Horoscopes, Bristol, U.K.: Cinnabar Books, 1997, Chart #358, p. 395.

[3] Ibid., Chart #92, p. 147.

[4] Greene, Saturno, pág. 140, 189; Los Planetas Exteriores y sus Ciclos. Editorial

Barath, Madrid, 1988.

[5] Liz Greene, The Horoscope in Manifestation, London: CPA Press, 1997.

[6] Ibid., p. 103.

[7] Eve Jackson, "Monty Python, Pluto and the Fool," Transit, No. 43, November 1983, pp. 13-17.

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El artículo original apareció en la revista astrológica americana "The Mountain Astrologer" (Dic/Ene 2002), cuya edición todavía está disponible en su página web:

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Nick Campion: Desde la segunda guerra mundial, nuestra entera experiencia astrológica de Plutón, estuvo coloreada por el largo sextil con Neptuno; hace unos años, Neptuno y Plutón entraron en Acuario y Sagitario respectivamente. En ese momento, en la conferencia AA en 1997, tu señalabas que Plutón en Sagitario también coincidía con el comienzo del Renacimiento a mitad del siglo XVIII y en Relaciones, tu hablas de cómo cada comienzo de una nueva era presenta sus héroes. Mencionas a Goethe, Swedenborg y otros, como a los héroes que produjo ese período.[8] ¿Tienes alguna idea sobre cuáles pueden ser los héroes actuales de esta era o cómo podrían ser?

Liz Greene: ¿Quizá como Buffy, el Vampiro Asesino?

Nick Campion: Sí.

Liz Greene: ¿Crees que es una broma?

Nick Campion: No, has puesto el dedo en la llaga; la fascinación por la oscuridad y los misterios en la televisión, desde Buffy a Expedientes X y todas sus secuelas.

Liz Greene: Hay mucha sabiduría en Buffy. El reino Plutoniano retratado en la serie es principalmente demoníaco, lo cual es una perspectiva muy estrecha. Sin embargo, la forma en que el reino Plutoniano se entreteje con la vida ordinaria, hace que el programa sea muy original. Es una de las formas de intentar trabajar con esta clase de cosas. Hay una aceptación de que forman parte de la vida. Así que tenemos la absurda yuxtaposición de vampiros irrumpiendo en los gimnasios de una escuela secundaria americana, lo cual es precisamente, lo que sucede con Plutón. No es algo "distinto" que se debe desenterrar. Está por doquier. Como una vez lo hicieron los cuentos de hadas, esta clase de programas sirve a algún propósito psíquico. Por eso la gente los ve: Presentan

patrones internos de una forma digerible, interesante y divertida y uno no se da cuenta que brindan soluciones al mismo tiempo que entretienen. Son un equivalente moderno a los cuentos de hadas. Sin embargo, últimamente no he visto muchos héroes modernos.

Nick Champion: Es difícil, ¿no es así?, porque vivimos en una época antihéroe.

Liz Greene: Definitivamente. No creo que nuestros héroes por el momento vayan a ser algo reconocible, no con Neptuno y Urano en Acuario. No nos gustan los héroes, son políticamente incorrectos. Tenemos que encontrarlos en películas, en novelas y en la televisión.

Nick Champion: ¿Qué pasa con la generación "Yo" con Plutón en Leo? ¿Hay algo que dice "Como yo también puedo ser un héroe no voy a reconocer tu heroísmo?"

Liz Greene: No, creo que son los que han creado series como Expedientes X y Buffy. Todos ellos son gente con Plutón en Leo. La forma de participación de la generación de Plutón en Leo, en la supervivencia de la naturaleza, esa determinación de que la vida continúe a pesar de todo, es confirmar el poder creativo individual. Y siguen haciéndolo. Lo hacen de manera diferente a la gente con Plutón en Virgo, en Libra o en Escorpio. Las distintas generaciones, a medida que Plutón cambia de signo, describen o rotulan la manera en que el instinto de supervivencia (esa parte individual de la crudeza de la naturaleza) se activa cuando la suerte está echada y la personalidad individual ya no es relevante o queda avasallada. Entonces, aparece Plutón.

Nick Champion: ¿Tienes alguna idea de cómo se está manifestando la generación Urano-Plutón?. Son los que nacieron durante la era hippy y recuerdo la desilusión en los setenta, cuando todo el mundo decía, "La era de los hippies no llegó a nada". Pero por supuesto, los hippies tuvieron hijos.

Liz Greene: Sí.

Nick Champion: Y aquellos niños están ahora en su cuarta década. Los Punks se están convirtiendo en abuelos. Supongo que los identificamos como la "generación de la informática".

Liz Greene: Están al final de su tercera década. Todavía no han atravesado la oposición de Urano. Sí, son la generación de la informática, pero creo que también están muy relacionados con los grandes temas de los 60, intentar volver a la naturaleza, los productos y los ciclos naturales y la armonía con la Tierra. No eran tanto anti tecnología como anti

industrialización y este tema proviene realmente, del grupo Urano-Plutón. Toda la conciencia que ahora se tiene acerca la alimentación y el movimiento pro comida orgánica, proviene realmente de esta generación. Esto es lo que están logrando en términos mundanos y todavía no han terminado. Todavía ni siquiera ocupan posiciones de autoridad que se espera ocupen al final de su cuarta década, principios de la quinta, cuando la gente alcanza altos cargos en el gobierno. Aún, tenemos que ver que más pueden hacer.

Nick Champion: Y les siguen atrás los jóvenes que ahora tienen veinte, que son los que nacieron con la conjunción Saturno-Plutón en Libra, que imagino son los que protestan contra el Fondo Monetario Internacional y la Organización Mundial de Comercio.

Liz Greene: Sí.

Nick Champion: El ciclo Saturno-Plutón está también relacionado con la independencia de la India y de Israel en los 40. Dos antiguas culturas, los hindúes y los judíos, lograron restaurar sus Estados. ¿Percibís que los individuos con Saturno-Plutón transmiten una influencia arcaica similar?

Liz Greene: Creo que acarrean una larga historia o son concientes de su largo pasado. La conciencia histórica no es un ingrediente común en la visión del mundo de mucha gente. Muchos se las arreglan muy bien sin ella. Saturno-Plutón realmente parece reflejar una conciencia de esta historia mucho más larga que se vuelve al pasado a través de ciclos, a través de las muertes y renacimientos y metamorfosis. Parte de la gran fuerza potencial que tiene, es un conocimiento instintivo de la relevancia de la historia y del hecho de que cualquier cosa que se construya, históricamente, un día morirá.

Nick Champion: Esta idea, de que cualquier cosa que construyas un día morirá, apunta al concepto de apogeo y decadencia de las culturas, de acuerdo con las eras astrológicas. En "Relaciones Humanas", hablas de la Era de Acuario, como Dios o los dioses, están ahora dentro nuestro y no ya en el exterior y la ciencia es una manifestación acuariana.[9] Creo que podríamos considerarte una humanista, porque ahora somos el centro de todo. También, existe el concepto de la relatividad cultural, implícita, quizá, en todo el pensamiento de la Nueva Era, reivindicando que cada era tiene su versión de la verdad y ninguna es superior a la otra.

Liz Greene: No creo que las eras astrológicas sean en este sentido más o menos reales que cualquier otra cosa. Pero sí parecen existir momentos claves, en términos de cómo los seres humanos definen el

Bien Supremo o cualquier otra manera en que se refieran a Dios y la forma en que expresan en acciones esas percepciones. Por lo tanto, no creo que una edad sea mejor que otra, en el sentido de estar más cerca de la verdad. En el mundo antiguo, los dioses eran percibidos como seres que estaban "en otro lugar" e intervenían en la vida humana. Ahora, nos está costando mucho definir a los dioses de esa manera. Esto quizá no implique, necesariamente, una mayor conciencia de la verdad. Sólo es lo que ahora percibimos como real. Fragmentamos y desintegramos la atribución de la divinidad en algo que está "allí afuera" y a la que le rezamos. Esta desintegración parece causar muchos problemas, ansiedad y la sensación de amenaza y la respuesta es la constelación de lo opuesto, el fundamentalismo rígido. Esta es la visión de Prometeo, en la cual los seres humanos son el alfa y el omega, todo se asienta en nosotros.

Preguntar si esto es verdad o no, es erróneo. Es aquello con lo que vivimos y con lo que vamos a convivir por un largo tiempo. Haremos un gran alboroto al respecto, porque provoca una gran arrogancia. Con cada cambio en la percepción de la divinidad, perdemos algo. Ganamos una nueva percepción y perdemos algo precioso. Parece ser más una cuestión de si podemos conservar lo que es de valor de la antigua percepción, mientras que, al mismo tiempo, nos permitimos concebir una nueva, en lugar de trazar una línea y decir "fuera lo viejo". La Cristiandad intentó expulsar cruelmente la visión pagana del mundo y creo que pagó un precio terrible por la exclusión de lo que la antigua visión tenía de valor. Ahora nosotros, estamos en la misma posición.

Nick Champion: Entonces, cuando tu escribes en Astrology for Lovers(Astrología para Enamorados) que como individuos siempre estamos transformándonos[10], ¿Crees que la sociedad humana está también en constante proceso de transformación? De todo lo que acabas de decir deduzco tu neutralidad respecto de esa transformación y de aquello en lo que nos convertimos, lo cual no es necesariamente mejor que lo que éramos antes.

Liz Greene: Podría ser mejor, pero no creo que haya ningún postulado que diga que definitivamente lo será. De haberlo, quizá tenga más que ver con nuestro potencial que con un grandioso designio de la evolución. Es un poco como la vida humana. Para cuando alcanzamos una cierta edad, las experiencias han empezado a volverse cíclicas y empiezas a reconocer ya que has estado antes en ese lugar. Esto puede ser mejor en términos de sabiduría o de ser más hábil para atravesar las

situaciones o manejarlas con más creatividad. También, puede volver a la gente más amarga y destructiva, porque se alteran al darse cuenta de que ya vivió esa situación antes. Creo que existe el potencial de una genuina evolución, pero no creo que sea algo dado. Tampoco estoy convencida de que sea un plan. Es algo que realmente podríamos hacer nosotros mismos si fuésemos lo suficientemente inteligentes para manejarlo.

Nick Champion: Me sorprendió tu ataque a los gurúes de la Nueva Era en Neptuno.[11] Precisamente lo encontré muy interesante, porque el mundo exterior clasifica a todos los astrólogos como miembros de la Nueva Era y por lo tanto, un tanto excéntrico que hubiera una astróloga que realmente criticara los excesos de los gurúes.

Liz Greene: Siempre me gustó la frase de John Cooper Powys: "El diablo es cualquier dios que empieza a exigir obediencia". Cualquier autoridad puede convertirse en diablo, ya sea la "Espiritualidad de la Nueva Era" bajo la forma de un gurú, o la religión ortodoxa, en la persona del Papa, o la ciencia, en la forma de alto poder académico o la política, cuando empezamos a dejar que otros pongan en práctica la capacidad de discriminar por nosotros.

"Verdad" es una palabra terrible, porque realmente depende del que la pronuncia. Si relegamos la necesidad de luchar individualmente para descubrir lo que entendemos es la verdad, nos comportamos como idiotas. No atacé realmente a los gurúes por el hecho de serlo. Uno puede convertir a su médico en un gurú. También, se puede convertir al gobierno en un gurú, que fue lo que hicieron los rusos en la era Soviética y lo que mucha gente hace con el gobierno inglés ahora. Se puede convertir cualquier cosa en un gurú, si uno quiere ser un niño que necesita un padre que tenga todas las respuestas. No creo que eso tenga nada que ver con la "Nueva Era". Creo que tiene que ver con un aspecto de los seres humanos que no quiere hacer el esfuerzo necesario. Fundamentalmente somos criaturas perezosas y la dependencia de los gurúes, es una manifestación de nuestra pereza.

Nick Champion: Hay algo más que tú dices sobre la Era de Acuario en uno de los seminarios de los Planetas Exteriores y su Ciclos.[12] Alguien te preguntó cuando comenzaba la Era de Acuario y tú dijiste. "Por lo que yo sé la Era de Acuario comenzó el jueves pasado", lo cual resume la ridícula necesidad de algunas personas de absoluta certeza.

Liz Greene: Sí bastante.

Nick Champion: El miembro de la audiencia respondió: "No puedo evitar

sentirme decepcionado por lo que estás diciendo”.

Liz Greene: Sí, me ocurre a menudo. Alguien siempre se decepciona si no le doy la respuesta exacta. ¡Oh cielos!

Nick Campion: También, puedes ser candidata a convertirte en gurú.

Liz Greene: Para mucha gente sí. Tengo clientes que intentan convertirme en uno y me desespero, porque sé desde el principio que si alguien con esa mentalidad me pide que le interprete su carta, se decepcionará con cualquier cosa que le diga, porque no será “La Respuesta”. De hecho, trato de evitar ese tipo de clientes.

Nick Campion: ¿Puedes saberlo de antemano?

Liz Greene: Normalmente sí. Presentan un cierto matiz. Si les pregunto por teléfono, “¿Por qué quieres hacerte la carta?” Lo percibo enseguida. A veces, está bien, pero la mayoría de las veces si alguien busca a un gurú, realmente la astrología no se los dará. Buscan una deidad paternal que les haga sentirse seguros y a salvo y les dé todas las respuestas para no volver a sentir miedo nunca más. Aunque siento mucha compasión por la gente que está en ese estado, porque todos lo atravesamos de alguna manera, tratarlo no pertenece al campo de la astrología. La comprensión que ofrece la astrología pasa por otro lado. Apunta a “Siga adelante. Construya una vida y trabaje en ello”. Esta no es justamente una respuesta cósmica. Cualquier astrólogo que brinde ese tipo de respuestas, probablemente, no hace su trabajo de una forma muy realista.

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[8] Liz Greene, Relaciones Humanas, Un enfoque psicológico de la Astrología, Ediciones Urano, Barcelona, 1992.

[9] Ibid., pp. 224-225.

[10] Liz Greene, Astrology for Lovers, London: Unwin, 1986, p. 119.

[11] Liz Greene, Neptuno. Ediciones Urano, 2000.

[12] Liz Greene, Los Planetas Exteriores y sus Ciclos. Editorial Barath, Madrid, 1988.

Liz Greene and I met in London on August 14, 2001, to discuss her work in astrology - and her attitudes toward it. In Part One of this interview (which appeared in The Mountain Astrologer, Dec. 2001/Jan. 2002), we talked about Liz's thoughts on the current Saturn-Pluto opposition. In Part Two, we cover her background in astrology and her conclusions concerning its nature and practice. The original article appeared in the American astrological magazine "The Mountain Astrologer" (Feb/Mar 2002). The edition

is still available on their website

<http://www.astro.com/cgi/redirect.cgi/www.mountainastrologer.com/>

Part 1, Part 2, Part 3, Part 4

Nick Campion: Liz, a fairly crucial question to start: How exactly did you get into astrology? Was it a gradual discovery or a sudden revelation?

Liz Greene: It was probably more sudden than gradual. I don't remember a time when I wasn't conscious of astrology; going back to childhood, I think it was always there. I had no issue about it, but when I was at university, I went to an astrologer to have my own chart done, and that was really the kick off. It intrigued me, and I wanted to know how it worked, so I started teaching myself.

Nick Campion: You must have been in your early twenties.

Liz Greene: I was nineteen. I had some friends who were going to see Isabel Hickey, and they said, "Why don't you go and get your chart done?" So, she was the person. She seems to have been the main astrological figure on the East Coast of the United States at that time. A lot of people knew her, including Howard Sasportas and Darby Costello[13]. Many people passed through Isabel Hickey's portals. She was a fairly die-hard theosophist, very esoterically inclined and quite dogmatic. But her astrology was sound, and her belief system suited the times.

Nick Campion: And what were you studying at university?

Liz Greene: Psychology.

Nick Campion: Was that your major long-term interest?

Liz Greene: Yes. It started when I found a copy of Freud's Interpretation of Dreams at the age of twelve.

Nick Campion: So, you were a child prodigy?

Liz Greene: Well, I was certainly a child Freudian!

Nick Campion: Was discovering Freud a real revelation?

Liz Greene: It was a major revelation. Suddenly the penny dropped. It wasn't that everything Freud said immediately made sense to me, but the presentation of the fact that human beings have another side that they don't know about - that there are unconscious processes always at work in them - made perfect sense. I knew that anyway, but nobody would believe me. So, here was a piece of writing that confirmed what was clearly visible to me at a very young age. I started investigating. I started reading anything I could on psychology, as well as any literature that dealt

with psychological issues. My inspiration was mainly psychology and psychologically inspired literature rather than astrology.

Nick Campion: Was your psychology degree Freudian-oriented? Was it behavioural?

Liz Greene: It was behavioural.

Nick Campion: Rats in cages?

Liz Greene: Yes, rats in cages. And lots of sociology and statistics, which I hated. But I think I understood, even then, that it was necessary to have a piece of paper, a qualification, so I put up with it.

Nick Campion: So, you discovered astrology while you were studying for your degree. Did astrology then open something up when you were nineteen, like the discovery of Freud had when you were twelve?

Liz Greene: Yes, certainly. Astrology made sense of psychology. Exactly as when I discovered Freud, something suddenly went "click". Astrology showed me aspects of ourselves that we don't normally notice, facets of life which we don't usually understand.

Nick Campion: And so you saw an immediate connection between astrology and the psychology you had already been studying. At what point, then, did you discover Jung?

Liz Greene: I read Jung at some point in my teens, but it didn't quite make sense in the same way as Freud. But I went back to his writing in my twenties, and then it clicked.

Nick Campion: And that took place in the light of astrology?

Liz Greene: Yes.

Nick Campion: Were you, at that time, working in the professional world of psychology?

Liz Greene: After I took my doctorate, I did fairly conventional, orthodox psychotherapy, including some Freudian techniques. I hadn't done any formal Jungian training at that point. I didn't do that until much later, in 1980. Before that, I did some training with Ian Gordon-Brown and Barbara Somers at the Centre for Transpersonal Psychology in London. That began to give me what I wanted - something that was very deep and thorough, that I could get my teeth into and work with in depth.

Nick Campion: Psychoanalysis gave you that depth?

Liz Greene: Well, yes, Jung's version of it. I am not a Jungian any more than I am any sort of -ian or -ist, but I felt the training had

more scope to help people than the Freudian training.

Nick Campion: Jung himself drew so much from astrology and the esoteric traditions that it is perhaps easier to bring the two together than is the case with, say, Freud and astrology. You moved to London in the early 1970s. I remember seeing your name in Time Out, the London listings magazine, as teaching astrology classes for an alternative organisation and thinking: "Oh, I should go to those" and then getting swept up in something else.

Liz Greene: That was in 1975-76. The organisation was called Gentle Ghost.

Nick Campion: Since then, in all your years of teaching and working with astrology, have you come to a working definition of it?

Liz Greene: Nice question! Not a definition in a "carved-in-granite" sense, no. For me, astrology is a symbolic system. It is a lens or a tool which utilises particular kinds of symbolic images or patterns to make sense of deeper patterns inherent in life that are otherwise impossible to grasp on an intellectual level, even though it is possible to experience them in other, non-intellectual ways. It is a means by which life can be interpreted in terms of the underlying patterns of its rubric. And that's why I think all the other lenses - like the Tarot, Kabbalah, mythology, literature, poetry, drama, painting, sculpture - are all not only equally valid ways of apprehending those patterns, but have fed into astrology while astrology has fed into them. I don't think there is such a thing as pure astrology. To say that is like saying there's a pure English race. Astrology is a lens, a system of symbols.

Nick Campion: It seems to me that, if we take the definition of astrology as a lens, this implies that the astrologer is looking at something; in that case, we can choose to put the emphasis either on what is being looked at or on the looker, the astrologer. Then we can ask different questions, examining how astrologers' perceptions determine their astrology, or we can talk about what they are looking at, what they are seeing through the lens. Does the lens distort it? Are astrologers looking at anything real? Do you believe that there is something real out there that is astrology and that we are actually looking at?

Liz Greene: It depends on what you mean by "real." The zodiac doesn't exist in concrete terms. It is the apparent path of the Sun around the Earth, which we have divided into twelve segments;

each segment is assigned an image and a set of meanings and behaviour patterns. But the zodiac doesn't exist in the sense that there are animals floating out there. So, on one level, the whole system is not real. This table we're sitting at now is the kind of thing that we define as real. If you take reality as something subtler, and you approach reality as being the connections, links, resonances, or correspondences between things, then, yes, these patterns are real. But there is no way that they can be measured in a quantifiable sense, according to instruments of so-called reality. When you ask me that, the whole problem is that I don't know what you mean by real. Or, rather, I do know what you mean, but if Richard Dawkins asked, "Is it real?" he would mean something quite different by "real" than I do.[14]

Nick Campion: I was using "real" in the Richard Dawkins sense.

Liz Greene: In that sense, no, astrology is not real. This doesn't mean that it doesn't exist or that it is not valid, but in his sense, no, I don't think astrology is real. I believe there is an objective patterning or interconnectedness or unity of some kind or a set of resonances. You can use any phrase you like, whether it is mystical or hermetic or any other language you fancy. And it does exist outside us. It's not just in the perceptions of astrologers.

Nick Campion: You open *Relating* with a powerful quote from Gerhard Dorn, talking about the unity of everything:

Knowest thou not that heaven and the elements were formerly one, and they were separated from one another by divine artifice, that they might bring forth thee and all things? If thou knowest this, the rest cannot escape thee. Therefore in all generation a separation of this kind is necessary.... Thou wilt never make from others the One which thou seekest except first there be made one thing of thyself.[15]

That's a very strong statement of the idea that astrology flows naturally from an understanding of the unity of heaven and earth and of the notion that the astrological experience begins with us. You also acknowledged modern, quantity-based science in the same book, and I'm wondering whether you still agree with words that you wrote 25 years ago. You said that "astrology is ... a map of the system of laws by which the energies of life operate - an astrology vindicated by statistical research and scientific investigation." [16] Does that represent your current thinking? I am

interested in that statement because it has been claimed that there has been a change in how astrologers view scientific research and statistics as a way of validating astrology, and that negative statistical results have encouraged an anti-scientific stance amongst astrologers. So, has your own view changed since 1977?

Liz Greene: I think that research is very valuable in astrology, in the sense that it can highlight patterns. Sometimes research reveals patterns that we don't expect, and our assumptions are challenged. So, yes, it is very valuable for us to do statistical research. However, I don't think it is valid from the point of view of trying to prove that astrology works, because if you have the kind of mentality that is dead-set against astrology, you will try to blow holes in the statistics anyway. And usually you can take any set of statistics and destroy it. Astrologers can pursue statistical research for their own purposes, but there is no point in trying to convince skeptics. If I do 300 charts during the course of a year for people born with the Sun opposite Saturn, and 80% of them either had fathers who left them when they were young, or fathers who died early, or fathers who abandoned them before they were born, or fathers who were cold and distant, that's statistical research. I can then say: "Well, 80% of the 300 Sun-Saturn charts that I have done have this kind of psychological pattern." It may then be useful for me to explore further what that Sun-Saturn aspect means. But if I took that research to somebody who defines statistical research in a more "scientific" sense, they would say: "Three hundred people is nothing. What you need is 3,000 and a neutral control group." Whatever you do, they'll find a way to set other tests. I think the research we do is very important for us. Whether it convinces anybody outside, I don't really care, to be quite honest. I think we need to do it for our own constant development.

Nick Campion: Then it seems to me that, in terms of definitions of research, what you have just outlined is a qualitative approach based on case studies.

Liz Greene: Yes, in small or large quantities.

Nick Campion: The issue of whether there is anything in astrology that is "out there" and "real" often comes down to the claims astrologers make for particular techniques or ways of constructing a horoscope and the house system. Competing house systems is one of the main problems in astrology from that point of view, quite

apart from the problem of the sidereal versus tropical zodiacs. How do we decide which house system to use, let alone which zodiac? You once said that "you should use the house system that works for you." That sounds like you are putting the astrologer in the centre of the equation, rather than the astrology.

Liz Greene: Only in part. I think that all these different structural approaches open a window on something, but it is a narrow window and no single one of them reveals the whole landscape. I think that's why they all have validity to some astrologers but not to others.

Nick Campion: So would you agree with astrologers who say that astrologers get the clients that they need?

Liz Greene: Yes.

Nick Campion: If you follow that idea through, then it is a very provocative one: There is a client somewhere, in a distant place, who is suddenly moved at a particular time to phone you up and ask: "Can you read my chart?" Is there a sense in which you are summoning that person?

Liz Greene: I don't know if it is summoning. I think we are back to resonances again. Let's say the Saturn-Pluto opposition is coming into square to your Sun, and that represents some kind of symbolic picture of what you yourself become at a certain time. You experience, or are buffeted by, or get in touch with, a particular kind of energy. It is both inside you and outside you. You may experience certain kinds of things in your life connected with that opposition. How you deal with them is very individual. You may say, "Right! This is a very hard, tough aspect. I am going to do a Ph.D. under this one" and make some use of it. Or you may lie back and be a victim and say, "Oh, someone's broken into my house" or "There's a riot down the road and they burnt my car" or whatever. The nature of the experience is connected to how able you are to deal with what you are at that moment. But equally, as an astrologer, you may get a whole run of clients who are resonating to what you are going through. So, you may see lots of Scorpios, lots of Capricorns, or people who are getting hit by that opposition themselves. People may come to you with a mirror that in some way resonates to the same thing you are resonating to. I don't think the astrologer summons the client. Rather, when you arrive at a certain point, things that resonate with that will come

into your life. It is not causal.

Nick Campion: If you use the word "resonating" to a materialist scientist like Richard Dawkins, he would no doubt have a physical explanation of what resonance is. Are you using the word in a poetic way?

Liz Greene: Well, it is also literal. If you hit a tuning fork, and there is a properly tuned guitar sitting next to it, there will be an audible resonance. However, if the guitar tuning is imprecise, there will be nothing. That kind of resonance happens on a physical level.

Nick Campion: Does that mean that we all respond to the music of the spheres?

Liz Greene: I think that we are part of the music, too. It is a chain of constant chords and resonances.

Nick Campion: Let's go back to your example of the Saturn-Pluto opposition. If somebody with that transit can choose either to be a victim or to pursue a very structured path, like taking a university degree, then what is the nature of that choosing? Is the ability to make a choice itself linked to another astrological pattern in the chart?

Liz Greene: No. There is something that operates within resonances which psychology calls consciousness. I certainly don't have a definition of what that is, except that it is Mercurial. Consciousness is like the Mercurial figure in alchemy. It isn't limited by or bound by astrological patterns. Consciousness inhabits and expresses through those patterns, yet it can operate outside and within and around them, and it is what allows us to make choices. I think that it's what transforms our way of responding to these patterns. Either we simply are the pattern and we enact it blindly, which is what happens in all the animal kingdoms, or we bring that element of consciousness to bear. The pattern doesn't then go away, but it gets more notes in its chord.

Nick Campion: Are you saying that consciousness is somehow something extra to astrology, something beyond astrology?

Liz Greene: Yes, I think it is.

Nick Campion: That sounds like what the Neo-platonic philosophers would have called Soul. They would have said the Soul is above the body, above the stars, even. But if consciousness is beyond astrology, what about the so-called conscious planets in the horoscope, like Mercury, Venus, and

Mars, as opposed to the outer, unconscious planets?

Liz Greene: No planet is guaranteed to be conscious. The planets should be seen as representing patterns. If an individual is aware of the pattern within them, the planet is being expressed consciously, but, just because it is an inner planet, that doesn't necessarily make the pattern conscious. Experience has taught me that. People may wander around totally unconscious of what the Moon means in them or what Venus means in them. Whatever pattern of motivation the planets represent is part of human nature, but we can be totally oblivious of it. We project it, we are at its mercy, we are buffeted by it, we become it, we identify with it, we're run dry by it, but we are utterly unaware that it is us. It looks like it is "out there" or it is happening to us, but it is in us - it is us. The fact that it is inner, though, is no guarantee of its being in any way connected with consciousness.

Nick Campion: But how do we know when we are actually being conscious of something?

Liz Greene: Hard to explain, that one. It has something to do with a sense of standing in a still centre and being aware - not just on an intellectual level but all the way through - of something that you know as your self, but at the same time you are not identified with it. There's some kind of space between you and it. So, if I am having a Mars transit today, and you say the wrong thing and I get really angry, then if I am unconscious of that anger, I just become angry. I don't even know I am angry. Out come the abusive words, or I take a swipe at you, or I pour my water over you. There's nobody home in the sense of a conscious individual. I have no idea of what I am about to do, what I am about to say, what I feel. I just act and then I say: "Oh, I am terribly sorry, I just lost my temper, I didn't mean to." However, if I am aware, then I hear what you said, and I know I am angry, and at that moment I may even know why I am angry. I may feel the anger, but I am not the anger, which means that I can say to myself: "Did he really mean that? What has he triggered in me?" I can then work on it; if I am still angry by the time I have finished working on it, I can then say calmly: "Are you aware of what you have just said? It was very offensive." Or I can just keep my mouth shut, because I realise that my anger has nothing to do with you: It is my problem.

Nick Campion: Then our own internal thought processes seem to

be crucial. If we do see astrology as a language, then could we talk about that conscious state of mind as being Geminian or Virgoan, perhaps? Is it analytical?

Liz Greene: I don't think that it involves analysis. Some people may think it out in concepts, but consciousness is something that can be watery, fiery, or earthy as well. It is a quality of awareness, which means that one is not identified with what one is experiencing. One stands outside it, not dissociated from it, but outside it enough to actually recognise it. You can recognise it on many levels; it doesn't have to be intellectual.

Nick Campion: So, when astrologers say in conversation, as they do so often: "Oh, I'm having a bad time because I'm having a Saturn transit," would you regard that as a wrong thing to say?

Liz Greene: Well, I say it too. But I know what I mean when I say it. To talk like that doesn't really communicate what is going on. It is shorthand. We don't have a bad time because of a transit. The transit is just a symbolic signature of what we are experiencing. It isn't causing it. I am not in the business of going around correcting everyone's speech, and I say it too: "What a rotten day! Saturn's on my whatever." It's shorthand.

Nick Campion: So, if a transit is a signature, then that reminds me of the astrological aphorism, one popular with Charles Carter: "The stars do not compel, they incline." Geoffrey Cornelius added: "They don't incline or compel, they signify." In that sense, are transits best seen as signposts rather than causes?

Liz Greene: I also think the planets signify. I don't believe they impel, compel, dispel, or "do" anything. They are simply signatures.

* * *

[13] Liz Greene and Howard Sasportas founded the Centre for Psychological Astrology together in 1983. Darby Costello is a lecturer at the centre.

[14] Richard Dawkins is Professor of the Public Understanding of Science at Oxford

University and one of the U.K.'s top writers of popular science books. He is also a militant atheist materialist and a strong public opponent of astrology, as well as of all

paranormal claims and metaphysical and religious beliefs. His attack on astrology is

available on the Astrological Association's Web site:

<http://www.astro.com/cgi/redirect.cgi/www.astrologer.com/aanet>

[15] Liz Greene, *Relating: An Astrological Guide to Living with Others on a Small Planet*, London: Coventure, 1977, p. 1.

[16] *Ibid.*, p. 274.

Nick Campion: One of the prevalent themes throughout all your work is the dynamic idea of astrology as a process or astrology as a path, and that we are all on a journey to somewhere. As I read what you wrote about Saturn-Pluto on my way here, I realised that you were also emphasising the concept of process and the passage through growth and decay that comes with linear time, which is evident through nature, society, and the human psyche. You also state that "these are esoteric concepts." [17] On another occasion, when a member of the audience at a seminar tried to involve you in discussion of reincarnation in relation to Saturn and Pluto, you responded: "I really don't know about the metaphysical side of all this." [18] So, what I'm asking is whether you, personally, have a metaphysics which influences your astrology or a grand metaphysical explanation of astrology? Or does it just not concern you?

Liz Greene: It concerns me on a personal level in the sense that I would like to know what in hell we are doing here. So, I will certainly raise the question. But I don't think that astrology itself contains metaphysics. There is no belief system attached to it. People bring belief systems to it; in a sense, you can't avoid doing that, because every human being has a set of preconceptions. So, it is impossible to say: "Well, I am not bringing my belief system to astrology." Everything I have just said reflects my belief system. I can't guarantee that the patterns that I perceive in life are really there. But I am pretty sure that something like them is there, because enough other people have been perceiving them for millennia. But as far as reincarnation, evolution, and questions about where the spirit goes after death are concerned - Do we have souls? Do we go to heaven or hell? Should we be Christian or should we be pagan? - I really have no idea. I don't think the answers to these questions are relevant to astrology itself. Astrology is simply a set of symbols describing patterns. If we

impose a spiritual or religious or metaphysical order on those patterns, that's fine. But it is a personal imposition and not something inherent in astrology itself.

Nick Campion: Would you say that astrology itself is a belief system?

Liz Greene: No, I wouldn't, any more than any symbol is a belief system. I don't know what symbols are, except that they seem to emerge organically as containers of a multitude of conflicting and complicated patterns that are connected in some way. We don't manufacture them, and we certainly don't believe in them. They are there anyway. We perceive them, notice them, and make connections between them. "Believing" in astrology makes no sense to me. It is nonsense to say, "I believe in it," because belief is something you do when you have no direct experience.

Astrology is something that requires experience and hands-on work to see whether it conveys any meaning or relevance. So, it is like saying, "Do you believe in your car?" No, I just drive it. I have no idea how it runs, but if it works, well, fine. People who say they believe in astrology are either using the wrong word or don't know what they are talking about. You can believe in God or you can believe in reincarnation, because we have no direct experience of these things. There are people who would say they know there is a God and that it's not a matter of belief. Okay, I can't argue with that. Maybe they do. Some people say they know there is reincarnation, because they remember the 16th century when they were burnt at the stake. Well, I am not in a position to say they are idiots or are delusional - or that they are fantasising something profoundly relevant, symbolically. I just don't know, and because I don't know, I don't feel it is appropriate to bring this into an interpretation with a client.

Nick Campion: So, turning to clients, then, have you formed any general impression as to what they want from astrology? The criticism is sometimes levelled at people who go to astrologers that they are looking for meaning - as if that is a negative thing - or that they are in search of security.

Liz Greene: There are as many different reasons why people go to an astrologer as there are people. I also think that skepticism and belief are two faces of the same pathology. The skepticism that makes people say, "People who go to astrologers are just

insecure," is the result of a misleading generalisation. You have to take it one individual at a time. How many years ago did I start seeing clients? If I started when I was nineteen, that's 36 years. I couldn't say that all the people I have seen over that period are looking for the same thing - or for one specific thing. They fall into rough groups. Some people come for purely pragmatic concerns. They simply assume that astrology might be useful and that they can use a horoscope reading to find out how and when to make a practical decision. They are not really anxious about why it works. Others come for psychological insights. Some come because they have run up against a wall with a relationship dilemma. Some come because they are quite wretched and deeply depressed, or they are on the edge of a breakdown and they are hoping that they can get some insight. Some people come for meaning. Some come because they want to know about their spiritual development. You name it! So, I don't think they fall into any particular category. And some of them, perhaps most of them, don't "believe" in it. They are interested solely in seeing whether it can help them, which is not the same thing.

Nick Champion: Do your clients share a recognisable socioeconomic background? I'm thinking of accusations I've heard that people who go to see astrologers are on the fringes of society.

Liz Greene: No, there's no pattern. When I started doing charts, my circle was limited because of the scene I was around in the 1960s. There was certainly a "type" of client then. My clients came mainly from the New Age hippie world, with an overlap of people in the music business and the theatre. People in all sections of society have always been interested in astrology, and there is no single type of person I have seen over the last 20 years. Any kind of client and any reason for a consultation that you can think of, they have come for a chart.

Nick Champion: Do you not even see a majority of women? Wherever I go, that's the dominant gender in astrology.

Liz Greene: That used to be the case, but increasingly now I have a lot of male clients. Interestingly, since I have moved to Switzerland, the percentage of men has gone up. I've also noticed it at my Zürich seminars, where there are many more men than there are in my London seminars.

Nick Champion: That's quite surprising, because I am used to the

overwhelming preponderance of women in astrology in the U.K. and the U.S.

Liz Greene: I think it's cultural, that one. I wouldn't say that there are more men than women amongst the Swiss students, but certainly, in some seminars, there are as many as forty or fifty percent. It depends on the topic. If I am doing a seminar on the Moon or Venus, more women will come. But there are differences in terms of how the collective perceives astrology in Switzerland. I get people from the Swiss government coming to seminars, as well as biologists and mathematicians - men who have no problem with being seen going to an astrology seminar.

Nick Campion: Is that particular to you, in the sense that you are known as a Jungian, and Jung was a man and Swiss?

Liz Greene: No, I don't think so. I think it is cultural. There is something very deeply wrong with the British collective in terms of its approach to astrology. The British suffer from hyper-rationality, and people are very afraid of the irrational. That is why the British are into Freud-bashing, Jung-bashing, psychoanalysis-bashing, astrology-bashing. It is a problem in this collective. It is changing slowly, but I think it is changing faster in other European countries.

Nick Campion: Presumably, you are using the word "irrational" in a positive sense.

Liz Greene: Yes, "irrational" doesn't mean "mad."

Nick Campion: It so often does mean mad.

Liz Greene: Well, it often does in Britain!

Nick Campion: Just now, you said that belief and skepticism were two sides of the same coin. This reminded me of a conversation I had with Alexander Ruperti at a British Astrological Association Conference around 1985. He was a student of Alice Bailey's and was deeply philosophical and very influenced by theosophy. He started getting very critical of Jungian and psychological astrologers, saying, "Oh, they don't know what they are playing with because they psychologize everything." I had an insight then that the theosophical astrologers who began the development of modern psychological astrology in the early 20th century had a spiritual metaphysics that was integral to their astrology, one that Ruperti accepted. But the psychological approach to astrology can, in fact, be deeply skeptical because it would argue that, if you believe in archangels and ascended masters (as a theosophical

astrologer would), then such beliefs might be no more than your psychological projection.

Liz Greene: Yes, they might be. But looking at things psychologically doesn't mean that numinous experiences are therefore necessarily a sublimation of a pathology. Metaphysical beliefs can exist totally appropriately on their own plane. Putting a psychological perspective on astrology simply postulates that, whatever these numinous experiences are, it is human beings who report them. Whatever it is that is being reported, psychology is not in a position to assess its truth or untruth. It is just that human beings bring their own psychological processes to bear on what they are perceiving. So, if a devout Catholic has a numinous experience, they are going to say: "I saw the Virgin Mary," while an Australian aborigine is going to say: "I became one with the land," and a Hindu will experience enlightenment through Krishna. Individuals create their own lenses through which these experiences are perceived. All that psychology can say is: "Okay, something extraordinary has happened, but we don't know whether they are angels or not." Personally, I am not in a position to say whether angels exist or not. I haven't the foggiest idea. But I am interested in the person who comes to me saying he or she saw angels, because that immediately brings in the individual and their psychology - and it is a good idea to know what kind of person you are before you assume that everything that angel said to you is the truth. That way, at least you have some room to breathe with it and to navigate round it.

Nick Campion: In Neptune, you wrote that "psychology itself, of course, may be simply another, more subtle kind of religious cosmology, as the anti-therapy lobby claims. The gap between the scientific edifice of psychoanalysis and the channelled esoteric teachings of Alice Bailey is not so great as one might think." [19] Aside from sounding quite skeptical, I like the idea that psychology is a religious cosmology.

Liz Greene: I think schools of psychology are like that, in that their teachings tend to become dogmatic world views. Each school of psychology - with its language, hierarchies, maps of the mind, formulations of what lies at our centre and where we are going - does crystallise in exactly the same way that any religious or spiritual group crystallises. The terminology is what traps us. If you

train as a Freudian, the Oedipus complex can become accepted as a reality, if you haven't got your eyes open and are not alert. The concept becomes a form through which you then identify other people's behaviour. But it isn't "real" any more than the planets are, in astrology. If you are a Jungian (and I have heard Jungians do this), you may talk about Jungian models as if they really exist. They used to do this all the time when I was doing my training. Someone would say, "Oh, I had an anima experience," because they fell in love and had a little affair on the side. The event is defined as though the anima is a real thing, a fixed point on an objective compass. But it isn't. So, it is psychology's jargon which turns it into a religious system, just as religious terminology makes religion into a system. People mistakenly use language as though it were a concrete structure that is the reality itself, whereas it is only language, and the thing it is describing is the same, whatever language you use. You don't make it more or less real by using different words.

Nick Campion: Do you think Jung himself thought that the anima was something real and concrete?

Liz Greene: I don't know. I suspect that he didn't. He was very tricky. But I think that he presents it as a system for the same reason that most psychologists present their systems. Don't get me wrong: It is not that I think language is a bad thing and that psychological language or astrological language shouldn't be used. I don't think that at all. It is just that to take it literally calcifies it.

Nick Campion: There has been quite a movement in astrology over the last 15 years to go back to a more literal astrology. The whole so-called traditional revival in astrology, while opening up knowledge in one sense, can also provide a safe haven for astrologers who are looking for certainties.

Liz Greene: Well, the same thing has happened with religion. We are all very scared; at any time when there are odours wafting up of chaos, or of things breaking down and shifting at a rate of speed that we can't control, then a kind of panic sets in on a collective level. Then there is very much a movement toward structures that will sustain us, and this has afflicted astrology as well as every other area. And it isn't necessarily a bad thing either, because fear is fear, and safety is very attractive at such times. But it is always a good idea to have one's tongue firmly in one's cheek - even if you

need a more literal approach - and to have some understanding of why it is needed at that time.

Nick Campion: Perhaps it's also good to have a sense of irony. In *The Outer Planets and Their Cycles*, you use the term "enantiodromia" in connection with the history of Israel.[20] What you mean is a sense of cosmic irony in which events turn out the way they are not supposed to. Is this linked to the concept of the shadow?

Liz Greene: Enantiodromia occurs when an attitude becomes very, very extreme. It then has a tendency to flip into its opposite and start behaving exactly like the thing it is running away from. It isn't just to do with the shadow. What happens is that, when you make an effort to keep anything out because of a deep fear or because you are simply not ready to deal with certain things, then you pull all the way over to one side. The further you pull, the more extreme you get and the more you lose the place in the middle where you could actually contain opposites. It is very mysterious how this works. You then take on the face of the opponent and begin to behave exactly as the opponent does, all the while accusing them of doing the very thing that you yourself are doing. You and they are doing the same. The issues and ideas polarise between two camps, or two people, or two groups, or two collectives that have something secretly very much in common. But neither can bear to stay in the place in the middle and live with the thing in common.

Nick Campion: In view of what you have been saying about the need to stand back from our ideas and question our assumptions, one thing I have always liked about the Centre for Psychological Astrology is that there doesn't seem to be any set syllabus. The syllabus is in a perpetual state of evolution, a bit like Trotsky's or Mao's permanent revolution! You see somebody doing some interesting work, and you have them give a seminar. So, how's the Centre for Psychological Astrology doing at the moment?

Liz Greene: It is doing very well. As you say, it keeps metamorphosing, but not according to any imposition of a structure.

Nick Campion: From what you said earlier, the Swiss seminars sound as though they are particularly popular.

Liz Greene: I enjoy doing them in Zürich just because it is a

different collective. I learn different things from the people there. But the school has always had a kind of organic, Mercurial quality. It has the Sun in Gemini and a Mercurial tendency to keep shifting within a very, very loose structure.[21] I have never had a grand scheme for it or a set idea of what I thought it should be. It seems to have become what it is through a number of different people having created ideas, through what students say they want, and through astrologers appearing who might make good tutors. The only things I have felt strongly about are, firstly, that it needs to stay small, which it always has, with no aspirations to become huge and unwieldily bureaucratic - thereby lies not just madness but defunctness. Secondly, there is no one system that is taught, no one approach, other than that the human psyche is at the centre of astrology, rather than the planets being perceived as things that do things to people.

Nick Campion: You said that the school has the Sun in Gemini. I didn't realise there was a definite foundation moment. I was just always aware of the evolution from the Centre for Transpersonal Psychology and then the Centre for Transpersonal Astrology.

Liz Greene: The Centre for Transpersonal Psychology was Ian Gordon-Brown and Barbara Somers's organisation. When we first gave the astrology seminars a loose umbrella name, we called it the Centre for Transpersonal Astrology, because there was the idea of twinning the astrological and psychological teaching. But then the word "Transpersonal" began to irk me, because it implied that the teaching was only going to be spiritual, so we changed it to "Psychological" in 1983. The chart is actually set for the time when that name was registered as a business name. It's not actually a business, but we registered the name. The chart appears to be sensitive to transits and progressed aspects. It's a Saturn-Pluto child, born under the 1983 conjunction in Libra.

Nick Campion: Does the word "transpersonal" definitely imply "spiritual" in your mind?

Liz Greene: It doesn't in my mind, but it does in a lot of other people's. Trans simply means "beyond," but it is often understood to mean "higher." The word itself doesn't trouble me, but how it is perceived does. I preferred something more neutral.

Nick Campion: Just to think about your teaching for a moment, I'm wondering which astrologers influenced you. You first studied with

Isabel Hickey.

Liz Greene: Very briefly. I didn't really study with Isabel. I think I went to two of her classes, so I can't count her as my source of astrological knowledge.

Nick Campion: Are there any other names that you would pick out? Did you read Alan Leo or Dane Rudhyar?

Liz Greene: I read everybody. I have always read everything that I could get my hands on, so, yes, I read Leo, I read Charles Carter, I read Dane Rudhyar. I still read everyone I can. I have found all of them immensely valuable. But in terms of real inspiration, it has mainly come from outside of astrology. My main source of inspiration has either been from psychology - Jung and Freud - or from other symbolic systems, like alchemy and Tarot, or from literature or poetry, theatre, opera, Shakespeare.

Nick Campion: And Joseph Campbell?

Liz Greene: Yes, Joseph Campbell, to some extent. Also, a novelist called Mary Renault, who worked a lot with myths and fictionalised them into novels. W. B. Yeats has had a huge influence on me, though I can't explain exactly how. Thomas Mann has had an influence on me. Arthurian legends have had an influence on me, as have Plato, the Neoplatonists, and Marsilio Ficino. I can't say, "I learned my astrology from so-and-so." I learned a lot from Rudhyar and Leo. I am like a jackdaw. I find anybody useful who has anything worthwhile to say. I hope that I am fair about giving credit when I write books, and I will quote my sources. But my real inspiration has come from literature and from psychology, rather than from within astrology.

Nick Campion: What are you reading at the moment?

Liz Greene: I am reading a biography of the French poet, Arthur Rimbaud. He is a great favourite of mine, and a new biography came out a few weeks ago.

Nick Campion: He erupted in a quick, Plutonian explosion as a drunken, lecherous, wild, profane, teenage poet in Paris and then disappeared off to Africa.

Liz Greene: Yes. But the poetry is the important thing, rather than the way he behaved. It is the poetry itself and the images that he uses. His use of symbolism is fascinating and penetrating.

Nick Campion: There is a vast world out there in the arts that astrologers often ignore - particularly in the visual arts - work

constructed by people who were influenced by the same mode of thought as astrologers.

Liz Greene: My favourite painters, Moreau and Redon, were steeped in astrology, mythology, and hermetic thought, and their visual images are wonderful. As you say, astrologers don't utilise cross-links with the arts enough, even when they are describing the same thing.

Nick Campion: Whereas astrology necessarily converts symbols into words, the visual artists don't have to do that. They can just stay with the images.

Liz Greene: A lot of clients don't have the privilege of doing that either. Many clients cannot think in terms of intellectual formulations of what a planet is doing. If you show them a picture or tell them a story or give them a passage from a novel or a line of poetry, it may click, whereas all the pontificating in the world on a verbal level is not going to get through. So, it is of value, not just for opening our understanding of ourselves, but in working with people.

Nick Campion: That brings to mind the old Zen trick in which the master forces the student to stop thinking intellectually and to realise that words only work to a certain degree. Are you writing anything at the moment?

Liz Greene: I have three projects at various stages of gestation. There are always new CPA volumes, and right now I am working on a volume on Mars that includes seminars by me, Lynn Bell, Darby Costello, and Melanie Reinhart. It's called The Mars Quartet.[22] Then I have another book in the pipeline with Juliet Sharman on the origins of Tarot symbolism. There is yet another project with my brother, Richard Leigh, which will touch on some of your ground about the millenarian use of astrology. For that I shall probably draw heavily on your book, The Great Year, which I found immensely useful.[23]

Nick Campion: You must have published about 15 books by now.

Liz Greene: Maybe 20, because the CPA volumes tend to raise the total without my quite noticing that they are doing it.

Nick Campion: I'm looking forward to your next book already! Liz, this has been wonderful. Thank you!

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[17] Liz Greene, Saturn: A New Look at an Old Devil, Wellingborough, U.K.:

Aquarian Press, 1976, p. 140.

[18] Liz Greene, *The Outer Planets and Their Cycles*, Reno, NV: CRCS, 1983, p. 50.

[19] Liz Greene, *The Astrological Neptune and the Quest for Redemption*, York Beach, ME: Samuel Weiser, 1996, p. 240.

[20] Liz Greene, *The Outer Planets*, p. 51; *Relating*, p. 272.

[21] June 13, 1983; 14.45 BST; London. See
<http://www.astro.com/cgi/redirect.cgi/www.cpalondon.com/>

[22] The book is already published and available under
www.midheavenbooks.com
as volume 18 of CPA Press.

[23] Nicholas Campion, *The Great Year: Astrology, Millenarianism and History in the Western Tradition*, London: Penguin Arkana, 1994.